In the distant future, a post-Modi BJP may see a short-term decline, since many new voters came to the party due to the prime minister's personal popularity. Yet, this is likely to be only temporary. This book has shown how the new BJP has built a deep and fundamentally new organisational structure in the districts, down to the voting-booth level. It fused a major offline restructuring of its party organisation and oversight mechanisms with the clever adoption of new technologies and digital tools. Leveraging digital 3G/4G technologies enabled a vast yet tight party structure that could be monitored on a daily basis. It also enabled its leaders to organise large-scale campaigns and verify this expansion in a way that was not feasible earlier for any political party.

The old BJP was much more dependent on the RSS's cadre network for mobilisation. While the party continues to have a symbiotic relationship with the Sangh, as this book shows, its massive cadre expansion after 2014 at the district and voting-booth levels was not only a structural transformation in its DNA but also a fundamental enabler of its political power. The BJP's expansion also changed the balance of power between it and the RSS. Between 2014 and 2020, it became the world's largest political party, overtaking the Chinese Communist Party. Unlike the Chinese one-party system, the BJP's massive expansion unfolded within a multi-party democratic system. By 2019, its cadre network was large enough to dwarf the RSS's—it had 174 million signed-up members, about twenty-nine times the estimated size of the RSS (see Chapter 8). It remains tied to the RSS for ideological reasons, but does not need the Sangh to mobilise votes anymore. If anything, the Sangh is now more dependent on the party.

When the Congress system started to decline in the 1970s, it took the party another two decades to wither away. Similarly, the party structure that the CPI(M) built in West Bengal after 1977 carried it through for another decade in power after Jyoti Basu's exit as its face in 2000. The BJP may lose power, but 'even if this new BJP system stops doing anything today', says the psephologist Jai Mrug, 'it will take fifteen years to dismantle this system.'[75] The BJP's consolidation phase as the hegemonic Indian political party is now over. It has a significant local footprint in at least 500 of India's 543